Sri Chaitanya's Sushma Boppana: 'Women have an amazing skill set'

"Education has been an eternal table conversation for us," said Sushma Boppana, Co-Founder and Academic Director of Sri Chaitanya Group of Institutions. Having worked with several MNCs in the US, it was but natural to come back to home where the heart lies. Sushma's parents, who are doctors, founded this institution in 1986. "Academics and education have inadvertently been ingrained in me right since childhood," she explained.

After graduating from BITS Pilani in the field of Computer Science, Sushma pursued her Masters in Information System in the US. "But I haven't enjoyed the facets of working on computer programming as much as I've enjoyed steering academics here," she said.

Sushma was brought up in a family where 'Beti bachao, beti padao' was the running mantra. Her father Dr BS Rao always stressed on the need for "an educated woman in the house". "The family stays healthy and prosperous when the women of the family are educated. This is what my father used to say," said Sushma, adding that Dr Rao always encouraged his wife Dr Jhansi Lakshmi Bai while attending meetings or delivering speeches. "Being a doctor and following a profession is different, but going out and meeting people to shape your organisation's future is a different ball game altogether," expressed Sushma.

Dr Rao motivated the women of the house so much that Sushma termed him the "most liberal man known". "When I came back to India, he never once pulled me back. He wanted me to venture out, create my own experiences and make my own decisions," said Sushma.

Running a school or any business requires good leadership skills. However, can being a woman leader be different? "Everywhere in India, every industry is male-dominated in a certain way. When I moved back to India, you won't believe how many meetings I've had where I've been the lone woman," she said, reminiscing the past. "It was a difficult task because I am not a teacher. I had to interact with so many teachers and I was a young parent with a one-year-old son. So, talking to parents and faculty wasn't easy," she narrated.

Sushma's mother was a huge inspiration during this time. "My mother had spent her time and effort there managing the classrooms, internal discipline and more. I grew up watching her for several years," said Sushma, who owes it to her mother for learning to manage people, while introducing new methodologies to help next-gen students do better.

According to the 2011 Census of India, 2% of boys are literate and only 65% of girls can read and write. How does Sushma see this gender disparity in the field of literacy among children? "When you look at younger grades, I think it's more women-driven. Most of the teachers there too are women. There is at least a 50% ratio between men and women. But when it comes to higher grades and even competitive exams like IIT and NEET, the ratio is very different - 10% women and 90% men," she said. Sushma is currently engaged in encouraging more women in that space. And it's not easy. "There is a lot of learning required for women. To be able to teach on par with everyone else for IIT-JEE is not easy," she described.

In the US too, there are a lot of women who don't study beyond the 10th grade, but there is no one pulling them back, insisted Sushma. "But that part is missing in India. If I want to study and my parents can't support me, who do I go to?" That's a question that still needs answers, said Sushma. However the positive side is that kids here are more driven, she claimed. "If we can support that, India will see a lot more entrepreneurs coming out of the system."

While employers need to give more opportunities to women, Sushma believes that the onus lies on both sides. "Women seizing those opportunities are essential. They need to be committed to understanding where the gaps are and have the confidence that they'd be able to fill in those gaps," she said.

After taking on the reins of the Group, her focus was on providing various streams, subjects and skill sets needed so that a student is given everything that is part of the chosen field. She pushed for delivering better thinkers, given the "limitations in the education system in India". From 2006 to 2012, the number of students from Sri Chaitanya going into the IITs or All India Medical Universities have gone up by at least 20 times, she said.

"India has this culture of not bringing everyone into the change process," said Sushma, who earlier worked as the change manager in the US for a large healthcare company. The growth and success of Sri Chaitanya rests on the team since every decision was made as a group, she stressed.

Sushma's dream is to make women independent and the way to do so is to prepare more women to face competitive exams and choose better career paths for themselves. She has a special message for emerging women leaders. "Be yourself and have the courage to dream and stand up to difficult situations. Believe in yourself. Women have an amazing skill set to multitask, observe and trigger positive change in any environment. I am constantly blessed to be a woman."

